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Culture (OWC): [Tallensi \(FE11\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1986-1987

Coverage Date: 1930-1987

Place Coverage: Tongo Village, Ghana

Section Title(S)

Introduction and methodological procedure

I arrived in Taleland in January 1986 in the middle of the dry season. The first few months I went with my guides and interpreters, mostly with the Tongo chief's senior son, to nearly all the earthpriests *tendaana* and chiefs *na'anam* to fulfil the procedure of introduction.

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My fieldwork covered the same villages that Fortes' work had centered on: the villages south of Tongo, among and surrounding the Tongo Hills and the villages around Tongo itself.² Baari, Zubiungu, Gbeog, Tongo Naayiri, Zoo, Wakii, Gorogo, Gbambee, Woog, Tenzugu, Sii, Degal, Yinduur and Zandoya. I briefly visited nearly all the *tendaanas* and chiefs of the entire Tale area. Moreover I undertook the excursions by bicycle (where it was possible) or on foot. After approximately eight months I had achieved enough of a command of the local language *Talne* to conduct interviews by myself.³ The openness and joking friendliness of the Tallensi made it very easy for me to take part in their life and to develop cooperative relationships and friendships. Their tendency to exaggerate was sometimes not easy to cope with.

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I would define my status in the society as that of an associated member. Notwithstanding my colour and my occidental way of thinking and behaving I tried to share in the life of the people as far as it was possible, necessary and convenient.⁴ In the first place my methodological procedure in the field was that of participant observation — living in the society. However there was a

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basic difference between Fortes' research procedure and mine: the differences in life-style. Since he and his wife occupied the colonial guest house, he lived constantly separated from traditional family life while I lived together with a local family.

Observation In
Research

The impulse to start field research on a social anthropological basis came from the book by Christian Sigrist (1967): *Regulierte Anarchie*, subtitled "Researches on the absence and the evolution of political authority in segmentary societies in Africa". In his study he works out a theory of the continuity of segmentary acephalous societies in Africa by studying the different monographs on tribes, among them the Tallensi. His arguments culminate in the conclusion that the norms of equality are still alive and maintained in spite of the centralized pressure of colonial rule. He published his book twenty years ago and this was thirty years after Fortes' first and longest stay among the Tallensi. I wanted to examine his and Fortes' arguments about the historical and present (dis)continuity of a segmentary acephalous society. Stagl (1979: 6) points out that the theory of segmentary societies actually forms "the central part of social anthropology". In this connection it seemed important to look at the effects on the political organization and social order of the Tallensi of a changing economic and social climate.

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² Cf. map in Fortes 1945: 14.

³ Of course, even after 13 months I was still far from being fluent in the language.

⁴ There were different phases of personal acceptance: the fact that I took part actively in the Great Festivals' rituals and dances, that I was able to communicate in their own language (there is a saying in Talne about English-speaking people whom they don't understand: "They are lying."). Another important factor was that I was working on the farm of my family.

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